



The Sensitive Dog

Understanding the dog in front of you

A **sensitive dog** is one that is struggling to cope and feeling overwhelmed. This can show up as lunging, growling, barking, snarling or biting. These behaviours are primarily driven by **fear, anger and frustration** — yet they are part of a natural repertoire of dog behaviours.

Releasing yourself from the pressure of how society expects your dog to behave, and shifting towards understanding the dog in front of you, is liberating. Once you understand that your dog's behaviour is their way of coping with stress and fear, you as the caregiver can best support them and help them feel safer. Like us, dogs are individuals: some are confident and outgoing and love making new friends; others are more anxious and fearful, preferring a handful of trusted pals, human or canine.

Dogs communicate through body language

Dogs don't use words — they communicate through body language. The '**Ladder of Aggression**', developed by **Kendal Shepherd in 2004**, is a powerful tool for understanding how dogs communicate.

The bus-stop analogy

Does your dog often react when another dog stares at them? From a dog's perspective, a hard stare is perceived as **shouting**. Imagine standing at a bus stop when a stranger runs straight at you at speed, staring — how would that feel? Dogs dislike being approached head-on and read it as a challenge, exactly as you would at that bus stop.

Through no fault of their own, some breeds naturally look like they are staring. **Border Collies** use an intense stare to herd livestock; **Pugs**, with their shallow eye sockets, can appear to stare. Docking a dog's tail — historically done to certain working breeds such as Dobermann Pinschers and Cocker Spaniels — also removes a vital channel of clear communication.

approach in a curve, not head-on



Quality interactions: dogs approach in a curve and give space. The dog with its head down and sniffing is signalling "I'm no threat."

A dog running off-lead is more highly aroused, which can be triggering to other dogs — particularly those on-lead who cannot create their own space.



Stress & the Nervous System

Why a sensitive dog reacts — and how they recover

Like humans, dogs have two branches to their nervous system that balance one another.



Sympathetic

“Fight or flight.” Triggers on fear or excitement — raises heart rate, breathing and blood glucose. Burns a lot of energy.



Parasympathetic

“Rest & digest.” Slows heart rate and breathing, aids digestion, conserves energy and helps the body recover.

Trigger stacking

Stress is a normal part of everyday life. But when a dog is **repeatedly exposed** to things it finds stressful, and isn't given enough time to recover, adrenaline builds up and its ability to cope reduces. This is known as **trigger stacking**, and it produces a more exaggerated response — the behaviour society often labels “aggressive.”



The **‘stress bucket’** is a useful way to picture this. Each stressful trigger adds water. Repeated exposure keeps **cortisol** high and the dog in a constant state of distress — which is why it can seem like your dog is reacting to *anything and everything* and no longer listening to you. When the bucket overflows, the reaction spills out.

The good news — how you can help

- As the bucket **empties** and your dog is no longer in permanent distress, automatic responses like lunging, barking and growling begin to reduce.
- Give your dog **time to recover** between stressful events — recovery is how the bucket drains.
- Create **space**: allow curved approaches and avoid head-on greetings and hard stares.
- With the **right support**, your dog will learn to cope better over time.
- There is **no quick fix** — progress takes patience, but it does come.

Your dog isn't giving you a hard time — they're having a hard time. Understanding that is the first, kindest step.